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Exploring cultural context and school leadership: conceptualizing an indigenous model of *có uy* school leadership in Vietnam

THANG DINH TRUONG and PHILIP HALLINGER

The need for empirical research on leadership in educational organizations across more diverse national settings frames the purpose of the current study of principal leadership in Vietnam. To date, the international literature on school leadership in Vietnam is virtually a blank slate. This research aimed at describing how Vietnamese school principals enact their leadership roles and analysing how the observed patterns of leadership practice are shaped by the Vietnamese context. In this study, we frame the 'context of school leadership' in Vietnam in terms of Confucian sociocultural values of the Vietnamese society and the institutional-political structures within which education is delivered. The study employed phenomenological research methods in a multi-site case study design. Qualitative methods of interview, observation and document analysis were employed to generate a thick description of how principal leadership was enacted in three schools in Vietnam. The study found that in this context, effective school leadership integrated elements associated with strong autocratic and moral leadership. The paper proposes a model of *có uy* leadership which is understood to describe a leadership style that responds to the context of the education system in Vietnam.

In contrast with research in business management, it was only relatively recently that scholars studying educational leadership began to recognize the theoretical and practical importance of examining leadership across diverse cultural settings (Bajunid, 1996; Dimmock & Walker, 2000). In 1996, Ibrahim Bajunid stated, 'Because of the diversity of national contexts and differing national conditions, a great range of practical and theoretical problems of the ways of knowing emerge and have to be addressed by educational leaders in their particular contexts' (p. 50). Over these ensuing decades, interest in the contextualized nature and effects of educational leadership practices has attracted the attention of an increasingly 'global' community of scholars. Nonetheless, a relatively weak base of empirical studies conducted outside of traditional centres of scholarship perspective continues to characterize our field (e.g. Hallinger, 2011).

The need to develop a more globally representative knowledge base on leadership in educational organizations framed the broad purpose of the current study of principal leadership in Vietnam. Today, Vietnam reflects an evolving blend of traditional Confucian culture, socialist political values

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and values emerging out of globalization (Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Lan, 2002; McHale, 2002; Quang & Vuong, 2002; Ralston, Tong, Maignan, Napier, & Nguyen, 2006). The nation is increasingly engaged in regional *cum* global integration that is challenging existing values and norms of behaviour throughout the society (Ashwill & Diep, 2005; Dalton & Ong, 2005; Doan, 2005; Duc, 2008; Duggan, 2001; Hallinger et al., 2015; Ralston et al., 2006). Within this evolving context, Vietnam's education system represents a key vehicle contributing to the nation's quest for political stability, economic prosperity and sociocultural development. Yet, to date, the international literature on education in Vietnam is virtually a blank slate (Hallinger et al., 2015). For example, Hallinger and Bryant's (2013) review of the East Asian literature on school leadership did not identify a single article related to Vietnam in eight core educational leadership journals published between 1995 and 2012.¹

This paper aims to describe how Vietnamese school principals enact their leadership roles, analyse how observed patterns of leadership practice are shaped and conceptualize an indigenous model of leadership effectiveness in the Vietnamese context. Here, we define Vietnam's 'education context' in terms of sociocultural values and norms *and* the political-institutional structures within which education is delivered. The study employed phenomenological research methods in a multi-site case study research design. Although we generated thick descriptions of principal leadership practices in three Vietnamese schools, due to space constraints, the current paper reports only the cross-case synthesis. By contextualizing the enactment of principal leadership in Vietnam, the research seeks to illuminate how societal structures, values and norms shape the practices that are perceived as successful school leadership.

Conceptual perspectives

In framing this investigation, we propose that political, institutional and sociocultural forces shape leadership practice in schools. Our study of school leadership in Vietnam sought first to describe the nature of leadership enacted by Vietnamese school principals. Then, we sought to link these patterns of leadership practice to the political, institutional and sociocultural contexts.

Leadership styles

Over the past century, scholars have conceptualized, captured, described and evaluated the nature and effects of different 'styles' and 'models' of leadership (Bass, 1997; Yukl, 2002). Within the general leadership literature, for example, we find many studies in which scholars have compared the effects of 'autocratic' (also referred to as authoritarian, hierarchical, directive, top-down) leadership and 'participative' (also referred to as facilitative, empowering, shared, collaborative) leadership (e.g. Bass, 1997; Eagly & Johannesen-Schmidt, 2001; Lashway, 2006; Quang & Vuong, 2002; Yukl, 2002). The prevailing discourse emphasizes that

autocratic leaders determine what is to be done, make and enforce rules, set clear standards of performance, utilize rewards and power to obtain compliance and employ sanctions and punishment for disobedience (Bass, 1997; Gastil, 1994; Lashway, 2006; Yukl, 2002). For example, studies conducted in Vietnam have documented the prevalence of an autocratic, top-down, directive leadership style among Vietnamese leaders in both the public (Painter, 2003; Thayer, 2014) and private sectors (e.g. Quang, Swierczek, & Thi Kim Chi, 1998; Quang & Vuong, 2002; Ralston, Thang, & Napier, 1999; Ralston et al., 2006).

In contrast, participative leadership encourages subordinates to contribute actively to goal development, problem-solving and decision-making in the organization (Bass, 1997; Lashway, 2006; Yukl, 2002). Participative leaders facilitate the work of subordinates, empowering and coaching them to find solutions to problems (Lashway, 2006). Scholars claim that participative leadership can improve the quality of decisions, contribute to the quality of employees' work lives and increase job motivation, commitment and satisfaction (Bass, 1997; Bogler, 2001; Gastil, 1994; Yukl, 2002).

We note that the leadership literature has traditionally focused on how leaders mobilize and use power and influence to achieve performance results. In recent years, however, scholarly discourse has included a more explicit emphasis on the ethical or moral basis for leadership (see Greenfield, 2004; Lashway, 1996; Resick, Hanges, Dickson, & Mitchelson, 2011; Wong, 1998). Moral leadership emphasizes the vision and values that underlie leadership behaviour, thereby establishing a common basis for action by the leader and followers (Bass, 1997; O'Toole, 1996; Sergiovanni, 1992; Yukl, 2002). Indeed, the term 'moral leadership' explicitly highlights the impact that leadership practice has on the lives of those being led, thereby implying an ethical responsibility borne by leaders (Lashway, 1996; O'Toole, 1996; Sergiovanni, 1992).

Brown, Treviño and Harrison (2005) defined ethical leadership as, 'the demonstration of normatively appropriate conduct through personal actions and inter-personal relationships, and the promotion of such conduct to followers through two-way communication, reinforcement, and decision-making' (p. 120). This definition emphasizes the relational dynamics of moral leadership, whereby leaders are expected to model ethical conduct, respect the 'voices' of followers and accept responsibility for the ethical consequences of their decisions (see also Greenfield, 2004; Lashway, 1996; Sergiovanni, 1992). Resick et al.'s (2011) review of the literature on ethical leadership identified a similar set of attributes characterizing moral leadership: integrity, ethical awareness, community/people orientation, motivation and empowerment and ethical accountability. They concluded, 'ethical leadership addresses how leaders use their social power by being both moral individuals and moral managers' (Resick et al., 2011, p. 436). Over the past 20 years, a complementary literature has developed on moral leadership in education (e.g. Greenfield, 2004; Lashway, 1996; Sergiovanni, 1992; Wong, 1998). Yet, as suggested earlier, neither autocratic, participative nor moral leadership constructs have

been applied in empirical studies of school leadership in Vietnam (see Hallinger et al., 2015).

The Vietnamese education context

Socialism was adopted as the political system of government with the establishment of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in 1945. Over time, values and norms associated with socialism have blended with the pre-existing Confucian culture of Vietnam (Ashwill & Diep, 2005; Dalton, Hac, Nghi, & Ong, 2001; McHale, 2002). Vietnam initiated the *Đổi Mới* (Renovation) and *Mở Cửa* (Open door) policies in 1986 (Duggan, 2001). These policies legitimated the adoption of selected Western models of social and economic organization, even while maintaining the socialist ideology and system of government (McHale, 2002).

More recently, in concert with the Open Door policy, globalization has continued to introduce new social values and norms into the Vietnamese society (Duc, 2008; Lan, 2002; Truong, 2013). Thus, a predominance of the twenty-first century scholars assert that modern Vietnam is best understood as an amalgam of values and social norms drawn from the Confucian culture, socialism and globalization (Ashwill & Diep, 2005; Bich, 1999; Borton, 2000; Lan, 2002; London, 2011; McHale, 2002; Truong, 2013). In this section, we define the political-institutional and sociocultural dimensions that comprise what we refer to as the 'modern Vietnamese education context'.

Political-institutional context of Vietnamese education. The organizational context of education in Vietnam is grounded in two dominant sets of structures, bureaucratic and political. The bureaucratic structure of education is embodied in lines of authority that fall under the jurisdiction of the Ministry of Education and Training (MOET). The MOET is charged with organizing and delivering education services throughout the nation. The central Ministry in Hanoi delegates responsibility for enactment of national policy to regional, provincial and local district units. Within this bureaucratic structure, Vietnamese principals hold the formal title of 'government officer' (Truong, 2013). As government officers, principals are, in a very practical sense, the government's representative at the school and community levels (Hallinger & Truong, 2014).

At the same time, the constitution of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam grants a leading role to the Communist Party as the 'sole representative of the people'. The role of the Communist Party as the 'leading force' in the state and society is formally embedded in the decision-making structures of the education system. In each school, The Communist Party Committee (CPC or *Đn e Bq*) is empowered as the supreme political organ in the school with a final say on the direction of any and all school practices. All school members, with or without political affiliation, must obey and implement the policies and directives of the CPC.

The CPC is led by a Standing Board or Executive Committee (*Thunsi vv ĐĐun bb*) whose members consist of a School Party Secretary,

a Vice Secretary and a Commissioner. Although the role of School Party Secretary is often filled by the principal, it can and at times is held by a vice-principal. Consistent with the socialist principle of ‘collective mastery’, the School Party Secretary holds the absolute legitimized authority to act as representative of the ‘people’ via the Standing Board, with authority that exceeds that of the principal (i.e. in cases where the principal is not the School Party Secretary).

In recent years, consistent with global and regional trends in education management, government policies in Vietnam have sought to decentralize governance in education (Bjork, 2007; Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Hallinger, Walker & Gian, 2015; London, 2011; Martinez-Vazquez, 2005; Truong, 2013). These decrees have been issued under the broad goal of increasing grass-roots democracy and staff participation in school management (Truong, 2013). Nonetheless, the main lines of authority that trace down to the principal remain largely unchanged (Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Hallinger et al., 2015; Truong, Hallinger & Sanga, *in press*).

Sociocultural context of Vietnamese education. Cultural values are generally understood as beliefs about what is good, right, proper and fair that are accepted by members of a social group, be it in an organization, a tribe or a society (Hofstede, 1980; Ralston et al., 2006; Strauss & Quinn, 1997; Triandis, 1996). These values are learned, shared and transmitted cross-generationally and serve as ‘cognitive guides’ for social behaviour (Strauss & Quinn, 1997). Although the influence of globalization is growing in the Vietnamese society, Confucian traditions remain pervasive and visible in the norms of everyday social behaviour (Bich, 1999; Borton, 2000; Lan, 2002; Ralston et al., 2006; Truong, 2013).

In this review, we refer specifically to two dimensions of sociocultural behaviour proposed by Hofstede (1980): power distance and collectivism. The dimensions have been linked directly to Confucian values in prior cross-cultural research conducted in Asia (Berrell, Wright, & Hoa, 1999; Gerstner & Day, 1994; Holmes & Tangtongtavy, 1996; Park, Rehg, & Lee, 2005), including Vietnam (e.g. Quang & Vuong, 2002; Ralston, Thang, & Napier, 1999; Ralston et al., 2006). In addition, education scholars have offered empirical documentation of their impact in the organization and management of education in Vietnam (Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Hallinger et al., 2015; Truong et al., *in press*) as well as other East Asian societies (e.g. Ho & Tikly, 2012; Truong, 2013; Walker & Dimmock, 2002; Wong, 1998; Walker & Hallinger, 2015).

Values that honour and reinforce hierarchical relations are inherent in the Confucian tradition. The influence of hierarchy is revealed in how people build relationships, use language in communication and fulfil their roles in the family and society (Borton, 2000; Ho & Tikly, 2012; Holmes & Tangtongtavy, 1996; Jamieson, 1993). Jamieson (1993) argued that the Vietnamese perception of the world stems from Confucian values which rationalize and legitimize the hierarchical order of society. The hierarchical values embedded in the Vietnamese culture are defined by Confucian beliefs about the role of patriarchy, gender, age, social roles and status. In

the Confucian cultural framework, hierarchy represents a state of affairs that appears both natural and unalterable to most members of the society (Berrell et al., 1999; Hofstede, 1980; Holmes & Tangtongtavy, 1996; Walker & Dimmock, 2002).

Vietnamese people have inherited Confucian teachings through the structure of society (e.g. family, community organizations and government) and as well as through the education system. Vietnamese social organization places a heavy emphasis on absolute obedience to one's parent, elder, teacher and boss. As a Vietnamese proverb puts it, you have to know exactly who is above you and who is below in the family or society order so that you can yield to those below and respect those above (*kính trên, nhường dưới*). Another Vietnamese saying is also instructive: Above has to be above, and beneath has to be beneath (*trên phải ra trên, dưới phải ra dưới*).

Hofstede (1980) further proposed that societies have a tendency to foster identification either as an individual (i.e. individualistic societies) or as a member of groups (i.e. collectivist societies). Vietnamese culture, as a collectivist society, emphasizes loyalty, harmony, cooperation, unity and conformity with group norms (Bich, 1999; Park et al., 2005; Ralston et al., 1999, 2006). Scholars have observed that Vietnamese people demonstrate a strong sense of familial affiliation and community spirit (Ashwill & Diep, 2005; Bich, 1999; Borton, 2000; Ralston et al., 1999, 2006). Dalton et al. (2001) suggested that although globalization has affected patterns of social relations among the public, the traditional Vietnamese orientation towards family and community remains strong.

The concept of 'losing face' also reflects this feature of collectivism. Borton (2000) asserted that 'loss of face is painful in any society, but unbearable in Vietnam' (p. 24). Everyone from childhood is trained to hold 'communal assessment' as the highest standard. Any success or fame achieved by an individual brings honour and pride to people or the community (Bich, 1999). Conversely, misconduct or failure of an individual is blamed not only on himself, but also on his parents, siblings and ancestors.

Methods

In planning this study, we believed that qualitative methods were best equipped to provide the depth of description needed to illuminate how contextualized patterns of leadership practice are. In this section, we describe the research design, sampling strategy and methods of data collection and analysis.

Research design

The study employed a multi-site case study design in order to describe and synthesize patterns of leadership within the Vietnamese education context (Yin, 2009). Case studies provide illustrative examples of people in real situations and offer a depth of description that is impossible to

achieve in survey research (Yin, 2009). A multi-site case study design offers an opportunity to highlight similarities and contradictions among cases while also maintaining in-depth description and a holistic picture of each case (Maykut & Morehouse, 1994; Patton, 2002; Yin, 2009). Although multi-site case studies enable comparative analysis, they are still oriented towards description, exploration and hypothesis generation rather than explanatory testing (Smith & Osborn, 2003, p. 57).

In this study, three schools representing different educational levels were selected as the sample: a college, high school and secondary school (junior high school/middle school). The schools, rather than individual school members, represented the analytical focus of the cases. This is because we approached the study of school leadership as an interactive influence process.

Selection of cases

The following criteria were applied in selecting the cases: school location, type of school, principal experience and gender. The three research sites were state-run schools located in the central region of Vietnam. School A was a state-run teacher training college. School B was a high school serving students between 16 and 18 years of age. School C was a secondary school serving students between 12 and 15 years of age.

The principal participants included a female principal and two male principals. Each had at least two years experience in their schools, thereby ensuring a sufficient base of experience in their particular contexts. Four vice-principals were selected based on their availability for data collection.² Six teachers were selected from each school so as to achieve a balanced distribution on age, gender and experience.

Data collection

Although multiple methods of data collection were employed in the study (i.e. interview, observation, questionnaire and document analysis), the data presented in this report are largely drawn from interviews. Nonetheless, we wish to emphasize that two types of 'data triangulation' were employed systematically in this study (Burns, 2000; Moustakis, 1994). The first was 'perceptual triangulation', in which data collected from multiple informant groups at each case site (i.e. principals, vice-principals and teachers) were compared. When differences in perception emerged, follow-up interviews were arranged to clarify the cause of the differences.

The second type was 'method triangulation', in which data collected through four different methods (i.e. interview, observation, document analysis and survey) were compared both for consistency and divergence (see Burns, 2000; Patton, 2002; Yin, 2009). Although qualitative methods do not approach validity using the same tools as survey research, the

authors made multiple efforts to check and enhance the ‘credibility’ of the data (Patton, 2002; Smith & Osborn, 2003).

Interviews are a useful tool for generating descriptive data about both past and current events and processes (Patton, 2002). They enable the researcher to gain perspectives from different individuals and role groups (Yin, 2009). This research employed semi-structured interviews with open-ended questions (Smith & Osborn, 2003). This allowed a dialogue, whereby initial questions could be followed up with probes based on the participant’s responses (Berg, 2004; Moustakis, 1994; Patton, 2002; Smith & Osborn, 2003). In this study, semi-structured interviews were conducted with the principals, vice-principals and teachers at each school.

Data analysis

All interviews were recorded with permission of the participants and subsequently translated from Vietnamese into English. A database was initially constructed for *each case*. This allowed for case data to be organized, classified, edited and coded into a manageable data file using NVivo 8 software. Once a complete database had been loaded into Nvivo 8 or a school, the data were then coded under four main nodes: ‘exercising power’, ‘building relationships’, ‘decision-making’ and ‘conflict managing and solving’. Within each main node, sub-nodes were created to highlight the themes and categories that emerged from each data source. Although sub-nodes within each of the main four nodes sometimes overlapped, this report focuses primarily on data related to exercising power and decision-making.

Each case study was analysed independently in order to preserve its distinctiveness and holistic entity prior to cross-case comparison. The study adopted phenomenological inquiry as a means of elucidating the meaning and essence of the data patterns arising within each case. This entailed developing an initial ‘structural description’ that contained the ‘bones’ of the experience of the group of people within the case site (Hycner, 1999; Moustakis, 1994; Patton, 2002). Four analytical steps were employed based on frameworks described by Patton (2002) and Moustakis (1994).

- (1) *Epoche*: We repeatedly read the database of each case to achieve a sense of the whole, then identified and categorized data aspects into the four predefined themes.
- (2) *Phenomenological reduction*: We reread the raw data and distinguished relevant meanings from irrelevant meanings. In this critical phase, we coded the data into free nodes (i.e. nodes reflecting concepts that might fall outside of preconceived themes or nodes) with the help of Nvivo 8 program.
- (3) *Imaginative variation*: We categorized data into the four predefined themes by re-examining the free nodes to identify the ‘units of significance’, and then incorporated, where suitable, data from the free nodes into the four predefined themes.

- (4) *Synthesis of texture and structure*: We paid close attention to the cluster of meanings within the predefined themes to elicit the essence of phenomenon. This involved an integration of structural descriptions, providing a synthesis of the meanings embedded in responses derived from each case.

Data analysis and synthesis proceeded in three stages. In stage one, case study summaries of leadership enactment were constructed for each of the three schools. In stage two, the results of the three case studies were analysed with the goal of identifying themes as well as anomalies. In stage three, findings from the cross-case analysis were synthesized in order to construct a conceptual model of school leadership in the Vietnamese context. Due to space limitations, this report is limited to description of stages two and three of the data analysis and synthesis.

Results

The first section describes the leadership practices and styles that emerged from the three cases. In the second section, we synthesize the findings into a preliminary model of principal leadership in the Vietnamese context.

Cross-case analysis of leadership practices

As noted, we did not approach the study with a particular leadership model in mind. Nonetheless, a number of broad but clear themes emerged from the data collected through our multi-method approach. Although different conceptualizations could have been employed (e.g. transformational, instructional, transactional, autocratic, participative and moral), the concepts of autocratic/directive and moral leadership best described the themes that emerged from our data analysis.

Autocratic leadership. When comparing findings across the three cases, a recurring theme was the frequency with principals were described as employing an autocratic leadership style in exercising power and making decisions. Participants emphasized the principals' use of 'power over' others or the use of position power with the goal of attaining obedience, compliance and control. In all three cases, findings indicated that a 'high expectation of obedience' was embedded in the exercise of school leadership by the principals in their interactions with staff.

In these schools, educational administration and politics were not separated, but structurally amalgamated. As described earlier, the administrative systems of the schools served dual lines of bureaucratic and political authority. In theory, the separate roles of the government officer (i.e. principal) and School Party Secretary were established with the intention of balancing power and guarding against abuse of power by school leaders. Nonetheless, despite the theoretical division of power between the

principal and the School Party Secretary, in most schools, the principal actually holds both roles.

In this study, the principals of School A and School B held the position of School Party Secretary and in School C, the principal was the Vice Secretary. Thus, both political and administrative power tended to be concentrated in the hands of the principal. Most participants admitted that the 'voice' of the principal represented the 'voice' of the Party (politics) and the 'voice' of the State (administration). School leaders believed that a principal's dual role facilitated the managerial process as it enabled more effective communication and support with these key stakeholders. As one of the leaders stated, 'It helps bring the directives and the will of the Party in line with the needs processes of administrative work'.

This tendency was also reinforced as leaders emphasized the need to build and sustain strong relationships with others in the bureaucracy as well as Party cadres. These were critical to gaining both human and financial resources. As one principal explained:

The school has recently received more attention and support from the MOET and local government. I think it is because the school plays a significant role in the local educational system and partly because we have built and maintained close relationships with government officials. (PC1)

Interview findings revealed the CPCO/CPCE had a strong political influence on school leadership and administration. School members were expected to implement the policies and directives promulgated by CPCO/CPCE. Indeed, the school leaders expressed their strong belief in the legitimate role of the CPCO/CPCE in directing the school. They emphasized the importance of faithfully implementing the CPCO/CPCE policy and demanding all school members to strictly observe the CPCO/CPCE's rules and directives. The absolute role of the CPCO/CPCE was also accepted by teachers, even by those without Communist Party affiliation.

It should be emphasized that this pattern of practice cohered into a norm that appeared quite natural to those involved. As noted earlier, leaders in all spheres of Vietnamese life tend to adopt a directive or autocratic style, both inside organizations and in the public at large (e.g. Dalton et al., 2001; Quang & Vuong, 2002; Quang et al., 1998; Ralston et al., 1999, 2006; Thayer, 2014; Truong, 2013). Criticism of leaders in Vietnam is strictly forbidden in the public sphere with jail terms recently handed out to web bloggers perceived as critical of the government (Thayer, 2014). A similarly directive leadership style was reported among these school principals.

Stakeholders accepted, without question, that the principal must be ready to use their position power to implement and enforce policies in support of the school mission. Indeed, in all three cases, school leaders broadly asserted the belief that it was the principal's 'responsibility' to use their position power to control what people did, as well as when and how. Cross-case findings indicated that all three principals supported the practice of using position power not only to 'influence staff' but also to impose their will or viewpoints on staff to move in a particular direction.

Acceptance of the principal's absolute authority was confirmed in interviews with teachers. As one teacher asserted: 'It cannot be denied that the principal's decision is the "biggest". There is a joke like this. "Article 1: the boss is always right; Article 2: if the boss is not right, refer to Article 1"' (C1MT1).

The leaders argued that although imposing viewpoints on staff might appear undemocratic, it was necessary in order to establish order, maintain harmony and ensure obedience to higher authorities. They believed that once order and obedience were established, schools would run smoothly and managerial work would be easier. The maintenance of obedience and order is in line with our literature review that emphasized the varying degrees of power accorded to people based on job rank, seniority and social status (see Dalton & Ong, 2005; Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Hallinger et al., 2015; London, 2011; Thayer, 2014). It was generally agreed among stakeholder groups across all three sites that it was the responsibility of a subordinate to submit to a leader's instructions or directives without question.

In the eyes of the respondents, acting contrary to this norm could lead to conflict or disharmony. In School A, participants agreed that discipline should be applied in order to prevent, limit or change uncooperative attitudes or when individuals did not respond to the collective interests (*quyền lợi của tập thể*). Interview data from School B, for example, indicated that staff obedience was seen as a way that staff displayed their respect for school leaders and the hierarchy. These participants agreed that discipline over staff should be tightened to make people more responsible for their work. In School C, participants believed that discipline was more critical to creating a good working habit for the school culture than participation.

Leaders were authorized to check any teacher's work without prior announcement. The leaders in all three cases revealed that they preferred using a combination of regular and unscheduled inspections to cultivate responsibility and discipline among the staff. In School C, leaders explicitly stated that they used unscheduled inspections to prevent teachers from becoming lazy. They claimed that this was effective in establishing a habit of self-discipline among the teachers. Similarly, leaders in Schools A and B confirmed that when regular inspections were carried out, staff were more responsible and became more aware of their own daily work. Their argument was that not all staff were self-motivated and self-disciplined. Inspections were, therefore, used to establish good habits and to get things done.

The common use of autocratic leadership based on position was further reinforced in discussions with the principals and vice-principals about decision-making and delegation. Most of the principals and vice-principals perceived 'sharing power' as a delegation process in which the principal delegated tasks to vice-principals with a limited degree of autonomy. Delegation was inevitable given the scope of the principal's responsibilities. However, all three principals emphasized their own accountability for all things that happened in their schools.

This latter caveat could explain why vice-principals in all three schools confirmed that they were not empowered to make decisions. Indeed, in practice, the vice-principals generally preferred seeking their principal's opinions or agreement before making decisions. Indeed, they indicated a general reluctance to make decisions based on their own judgements. In their view, this reduced the possibility of placing the principal in a position of accepting responsibility for a decision with problematic results that had been made by the vice-principal. Thus, in a sense, fear of disrupting the hierarchy placed severe limitations on both the nature and extent of delegation and decision-making.

Consistent with global and regional trends (Bjork, 2007), recent government policies in Vietnam have sought to foster decentralization of decision-making in the education system (Duc, 2008; Martinez-Vazquez, 2005; Truong, 2013). Interview responses across the three stakeholder groups confirmed the view that decentralization was a feature of 'modern leadership'. Thus, there was explicit discussion among participants at every level of the organization of the need for school leaders to engage broader participation in decision-making processes and promote greater openness and transparency in discussions with staff and the community.

Despite this policy-driven trend, the shift towards more participative management seemed to have a slow uptake. All three principals admitted that they continued to have difficulty in 'getting teachers involved in' decision-making. Similarly, interviews with teachers indicated that most of them were not very willing to express their opinions. This seemed to be a case where the policy change conflicted not only with existing socio-cultural norms but also with the deep experience of all staff (including the principals) within the political-institutional system.

Thus, cross-case analysis further indicated that efforts to bring about broader participation were bounded by traditional norms of hierarchy. For example, even while the principals described their efforts at involving teachers in collective decision-making, they evidenced a clear subtext that argued for the maintenance of position authority, obedience and compliance. As the principal of School A stated: 'The obligations and duties of staff are to implement leader's decisions strictly and seriously'.

Recently, staff evaluation of leaders was initiated by the Vietnam Communist Party as an approach to 'expand democracy within the Party' and promote democracy in school management (London, 2011; Truong, 2013). The principals asserted that although this approach could promote democracy, it might at the same time undermine 'harmonious relationships' between leaders and staff. For example, a poor evaluation of the principal or even one that implied criticism could subsequently cause rents in school solidarity. In sum, most of the features described in the literature on autocratic or directive leadership were observed in the three schools that participated in this study. Leadership behaviours associated with participative leadership (e.g. shared decision-making, use of expertise and consultation) were, however, mostly observed as formalistic efforts to comply with new government policies (see Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Hallinger et al., 2015; Truong, 2013; Truong et al., *in press*).

Role of prestige and moral leadership. Although the exercise of an autocratic leadership style emerged clearly from the data in these three schools, we also noted a complementary and quite different line of discourse. More specifically, participants also emphasized the importance of the principal's 'moral character' and 'prestige' in leading others. They conveyed the belief that leaders who were perceived as 'prestigious' faced less resistance and received greater effort, compliance, loyalty and respect from staff. Indeed, some participants viewed morality and prestige as keys to enhance the leader's formal authority (i.e. position power) and increase their likelihood of success. Participants suggested that follower perceptions of 'prestige' were linked to the moral quality, professional knowledge and interpersonal competence of the leader. This conception fits quite closely with conceptions of 'moral leadership' as expressed in the educational leadership literature (e.g. Greenfield, 2004; Sergiovanni, 1992; Wong, 1998).

Indeed, participants viewed the moral quality of the leader as the most important personal characteristic of a leader. For example, participants in School A asserted that the moral quality of leaders was even more important than their competence as managers. They mentioned that moral quality was important in assessing a school leader or a leader-to-be. In School B, participants identified a high standard of morality as a prerequisite for anyone in a position of leadership. In School C, participants agreed that leaders should have good moral quality (at least in teachers' eyes) if they sought more than compliance from teachers. In the words of one of the teachers:

To be prestigious, the leader must have wisdom, deep knowledge of the field assigned, frugal lifestyle, integrity, public-mindedness, "walking their talk", compassionate heart, selflessness, generosity, and so on. He leads and manages people by his good example and high prestige rather than only using the power to govern and impose subordinates. Such a leader obtains subordinates' compliance and submission by his dignity rather than by his power. (C2MT1)

Respondents in all three cases asserted that the moral quality of leaders was reflected in the way they set examples for subordinates. Morality of the leader was assessed, for example, by the extent to which the leaders' actions matched their words (i.e. modelling). Hence, participants asserted that leaders should be role models if they wished to cultivate a culture of trust in the school community. They argued it was a way of setting standards and norms of behaviour for staff as well as for reinforcing their moral authority. This was also recognized by the teachers who held high expectations for their leaders in this respect.

The leader must be exemplary if he expects others to listen to his directions or instructions. If the leader says one thing and does another (nói một đằng, làm một nọ), no one will trust him. He will lose his prestige. And of course, a leader without prestige is a powerless leader. (C2MT1)

I like leaders who are 'walking your talk', I mean 'setting a good example'. I trust them because they do what they say. When leaders walk their talk, they demonstrate how deeply they are committed to their work. They convince subordinates by their actions rather than words. They do much more than they talk. In that way, they set a good example for subordinates. (C2FmT5)

The leaders strongly agreed that setting a good example was an effective strategy of gaining the trust, respect and commitment of staff. As the principal stated:

Everything I do gets people’s attention. I consider myself as a “daughter-in-law of one hundred families” who is constantly watched by teachers, students and parents. What I do, how I behave, what communication style I use and so on send powerful messages to teachers and students. Hence, setting a good example is a way of setting standards and rules for teachers and students. For example, when I expect my subordinates to come to school on time, I must be never late for work. When I deployed the Government’ instruction on banning smoking at school, I was the first person who stopped smoking. (PC2)

The role of moral leadership within a strongly hierarchical society was further highlighted in comments from both leaders and teachers. For example, a vice-principal noted that her young age could be a disadvantage for her leadership in terms of exercising power. She explained the limits of relying on an autocratic style with older staff in the Vietnamese cultural context.

It’s more difficult to work with older staffs. I had the feeling, and I think other young leaders too, that I did not feel confident enough to exercise power over older staff, particularly with staff over 50. They are like my older brothers or sisters, or in some cases, their ages are quite similar to my parents’ age, so we cannot behave the way we behave towards the younger staff. (VP2C1)

The cross-case findings suggested that staff were likely to be more committed when leaders set good examples. Conversely, failure to set a good example could lead to the principal losing prestige, thereby diminishing trust among the school community. When implementing a government policy, a plan or a program of the school, leaders were always expected to be exemplary role models. The cross-case findings highlighted the contrasting features of high and low standards of morality. These features are described and compared in Table 1.

Table 1. Contrasting perspectives on moral leadership

Leader of high moral standard	Leader of low moral standard
Leader was perceived as ‘prestigious’ and ‘moral’ by stakeholders in the school community	Leader was less prestigious in the school community
Subordinates evidenced higher commitment and loyalty	Subordinates were less committed or only ‘superficially compliant’
Leader gained more effort and support from subordinates and stakeholders	Leader lost support among subordinates and stakeholders
Subordinates demonstrated trust in relations with the leader	Subordinates did not trust or lacked confidence in their leader
Subordinates showed stronger ‘intention to act’ and achieve success when receiving and implementing the leader’s directives or instructions	Subordinates might submit to the leader’s directives and instructions but could lack strong intention, persistence to overcome obstacles and commitment to succeed

Following the perception of morality, professional knowledge and inter-personal competence of the leader were seen as the next most important personal characteristics contributing to the leader's prestige in the eyes of followers. For example, in all three schools, the teachers indicated that they were more inclined to listen to leaders whom they believed to have relevant knowledge and inter-personal competence. The leader's prestige would be diminished if teachers believed that their own expertise was higher than their leaders. While this might not affect the teachers' willingness to comply with the leader's decisions, it could impact their levels of job satisfaction and commitment (see Bogler, 2001). Thus, stakeholder interviews identified the 'prestige' of the principal as a secondary source of power and influence.

Inter-personal competence, or the ability to develop trust as well as respect among others, was also central to the concept of 'prestige' in the eyes of principals and teachers. This is consistent with our earlier definitions of moral leadership which emphasized relational leadership practices. As one principal observed:

An encouraging word, statement or caring behavior from me to people is really important. It is important in terms of intellectual life and in terms of a sense of responsibility. When I asked a teacher who was ill for some days "How do you feel now? Do you need to have some more days off?" I could see the gratefulness in her eyes. I knew that she highly appreciated my words. Teachers need encouragement and motivation in that way to enhance their bond to the school and boost their responsibility for work. (PC2)

It is interesting to note that the cross-case findings indicated a somewhat surprising pattern in the nature and effects of these leadership approaches (i.e. autocratic and moral). When principals were perceived as lacking sufficient direction in their leadership, it could result in a loss of staff discipline, disharmony and disruption. Similarly, failing to meet a high standard of moral leadership, subordinates could trigger disrespect and rejection of the leader among the staff. In the following section, we reflect upon how this particular pattern of leadership practices is shaped by the context of the Vietnamese society and education.

Synthesizing a model of successful school leadership in Vietnam

As noted earlier, our qualitative case study research design aimed at formulating propositions and preliminary models that can be tested in future studies. In this section, we shift our focus from description and analysis to synthesis and theory-building. In this stage of the research process, we returned to the review of research and sought to place our findings in both theoretical and practical perspectives.

We identified two dominant trends within the leadership styles observed in practice: autocratic/directive leadership (Gastil, 1994) and prestige/moral leadership (Sergiovanni, 1992). We suggest that the preference for autocratic leadership was reinforced by the dual lines of political and bureaucratic hierarchy, as well as by the hierarchical values embedded in Confucian culture. More specifically, Confucian cultural values

implicitly reinforced the structurally embedded forces towards hierarchical authoritarian leadership at every level of the system (see Lan, 2002).

Our findings suggest that the paternalistic culture of obedience and respecting authority, as dominant Confucian values, has been extended into the contemporary structure of Vietnam’s society and schools (see also Dalton & Ong, 2005; Doan, 2005; Duc, 2008; Lan, 2002; Quang & Vuong, 2002; Quang et al., 1998). Within this political–institutional structure, the school’s internal power hierarchy tends to reinforce the broader culture of obedience and respect for authority. The schools were configured with legitimized hierarchal power and evidenced a clear tendency towards autocratic leadership. This was evident in the perceived need to maintain ‘collective interests’ even when it meant limiting the rights of individuals.

The practice of ‘moral leadership’ is inspired by Confucian values such as ‘*tu thân*’ (self-cultivation), ‘*làm gương*’ (setting a good example) and maintaining harmonious relationships (Jamieson, 1993; McHale, 2002). Moral leadership emphasizes practices that model core values to subordinates through two-way communication, reinforcement and decision-making (Brown et al., 2005; Greenfield, 2004; Resick et al., 2011; Sergiovanni, 1992).

The attributes of autocratic and moral leadership as practiced in these Vietnamese schools are summarized in Table 2. It can be argued that autocratic and moral leadership styles were both used to influence subordinates for managerial purposes, but that each style has its own strengths and weaknesses. Autocratic leadership yields a combination of compliance, obedience and sometimes even fear among subordinates. While this leadership style established order and could achieve staff compliance, it

Table 2. The attributes of authoritarian and moral leadership styles

Characteristics of authoritarian leadership	Characteristics of moral leadership
Autocratic (recognizing the importance of obedience and compliance from subordinates)	Showing care towards subordinates (recognizing the importance of respect from subordinates)
Using positional power and authority to influence subordinates	Using personal conduct and prestige to influence subordinates
Using <i>Lý</i> (rules, regulations, discipline and law)	Using <i>Tình</i> (focus on relationships, caring subordinates’ feeling and aspiration)
Led using authority and positional power. Regulate subordinates’ behaviour by strict discipline and regulations	Led by setting a good example. Regulate subordinates’ behaviour by setting role models (leader’s self-cultivation, fulfilling one’s obligations, etc.)
Maintain a level of aloofness with subordinates to retain leader’s authority and power, build the image of ‘condescending leader’	Tend to build close relationships with subordinates to create the image of a ‘sociable leader’
Emphasize assertiveness in working relationships	Emphasize harmony, face saving and avoiding confrontation
Status and power building	Prestige and reputation building
Rigorousness in work	Consideration and tolerance in work (altruism)

could also fail to create strong staff commitment towards collective goals (Yukl, 2002). Moreover, the abuse of authority could be perceived by stakeholders as 'bossy' or 'overly dictatorial', thereby making the working climate stressful and demotivating.

Use of a prestige-based or moral leadership style appeared to promote trust between the leader and subordinates. Moral leadership stimulated subordinates' trust, respect and emulation. Notably, this conception of prestige/moral leadership does *not* incorporate key facets associated with participative, distributed or facilitative leadership. Instead, it shares elements associated with moral leadership (e.g. Greenfield, 2004; Sergiovanni, 1992; Wong, 1998) and transformational leadership (e.g. Bass, 1997; Yukl, 2002).

Thus, in the Vietnamese context, we see two divergent but potentially complementary styles of leadership which we termed *có uy* leadership. We defined *có uy* leadership as *leadership that combines the use of legitimate and moral authority in order to achieve subordinates' obedience, trust, respect, commitment and emulation*. Behaviours reflecting an authoritarian or directive leadership style could establish subordinates' obedience, while those based in moral leadership could foster trust, respect and commitment. Although *có uy* was understood as an effective leadership style in this particular cultural context, there is no reason to believe that it would be universally applicable (Bass, 1997; Berrell et al., 1999; Den Hartog, House, Hanges, Ruiz-Quintanilla, & Dorfman, 1999; Gerstner & Day, 1994; Lord, Brown, Harvey, & Hall, 2001; Quang et al., 1998).

Figure 1 elaborates the proposed model of *có uy leadership*. The graphic suggests that when autocratic and moral leadership styles are integrated, four possible styles can be identified. These styles and their associated effects are illustrated in four quadrants.

- *Quadrant 1* identifies the leader who exercises high autocratic leadership and high moral leadership is practicing what we termed *có uy* leadership. The effective integration of these two leadership styles is proposed to yield positive subordinate responses including obedience, respect, trust, admiration and emulation. It obtains both compliance and commitment from subordinates.
- *Quadrant 2* illustrates a leader who demonstrates a combination of high morality and low authoritarianism/direction. The model suggests that in the Vietnamese context, this combination could foster trust in the leader, but also potentially yield an uncomfortable level of role ambiguity among staff resulting in confusion, disorder and lack of discipline.
- *Quadrant 3* shows a leader who is perceived to demonstrate low morality and a lack of sufficient authority in the exercise of leadership. This ineffective leadership style could yield a lack of trust as well as disorder and irresponsibility.
- *Quadrant 4* illustrates a leader who demonstrates authoritarianism, but low prestige and morality. This style may obtain staff compliance, but lack of trust in the leader could reduce commitment.

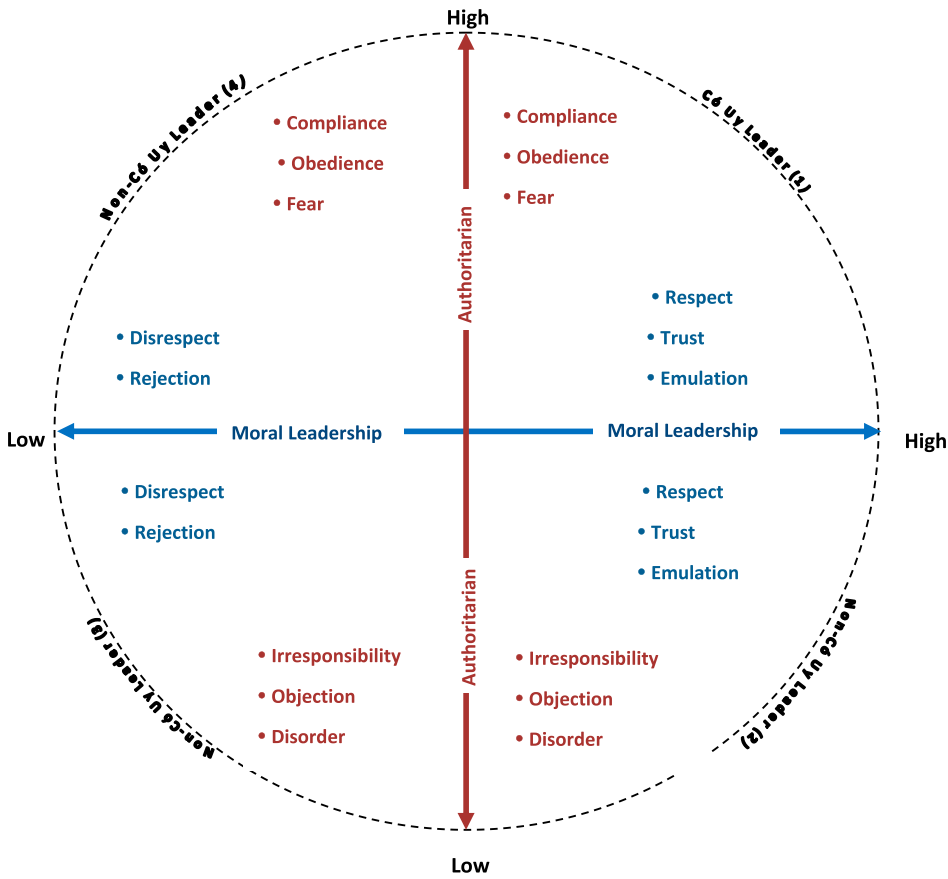


Figure 1. Conceptual model of *co'uy* leadership

Lord et al. (2001) stated that cultural values influence the types of leader behavioural prototypes that are endorsed within a particular culture (see also Gerstner & Day, 1994). In Vietnam, we have asserted that the combination of prevailing Confucian values and political–institutional structures shape the practice and perceived acceptability of leadership styles among subordinates. Specifically, Confucian cultural values reinforce the importance of social order and status relations, thereby making the exercise of autocratic leadership appear natural and normal. Similarly, values embedded in the political–institutional structures of Vietnam’s education system formally and explicitly legitimate the unitary authority of leaders and encourage the deployment of an autocratic, directive leadership style. At the same time, moral values embedded in Confucianism also highlight the importance of righteousness, benevolence, loyalty and harmony. These sociocultural values encourage leaders to act morally by protecting the face of others, showing care towards subordinates and guaranteeing subordinates’ well-being.

Although the practices that comprise these two types of leadership might appear in contradiction, the combination of these styles appears to

respond to values and norms of this particular context (see Gastil, 1994; Lord et al., 2001; Quang & Vuong, 2002; Quang et al., 1998). As such, the *co'uy* leadership style is highly congruent with Vietnamese cultural norms of hierarchy (e.g. social order, respecting elders and seniors and status preference) and collectivism (e.g. harmonious relationships, face saving, avoiding confrontation, the importance of self-cultivation and role modelling). The model suggests that successful Vietnamese school leaders should not only see themselves as carriers of authority who bear leadership responsibility, but also as the moral standard bearers for their schools. This conclusion is consistent with the Vietnamese aphorism: 'We need an iron hand, but the iron hand must be a clean hand'.

Conclusion

This qualitative study of principal leadership in Vietnam was undertaken in response to calls for empirical research that explores indigenous school leadership practices outside of 'Western mainstream' settings (Bajunid, 1996; Dimmock & Walker, 2005; Hallinger & Leithwood, 1996; Walker & Dimmock, 2002). More specifically, scholars have asserted the need for studies capable of contextualizing leadership practice within predominant political-institutional structures and sociocultural values and norms of particular societies (Bajunid, 1996). In our collective efforts to build a 'global knowledge base', these results can deepen our appreciation for the diversity of leadership practices perceived as 'successful' across different societal contexts.

While the study yielded contextualized descriptions of leadership practices, the data were limited to only three schools. Therefore, the conceptualization of Vietnamese school leadership synthesized from these data was only proposed as a preliminary model. Thus, we neither offer the *co'uy* leadership model as a prescription nor as a legitimization of current practice. Indeed, as suggested by our multi-faceted definition of 'the Vietnamese context', even generalizations to neighbouring countries are ill-advised.

In sum, the cross-case analyses yielded two broad patterns of leadership practice. On the one hand, the position power of the principal was considered the primary basis for gaining the compliance of staff to work towards achievement of the school's mission and goals. Descriptions of principal leadership practice cohered into an image that is consistent with what the literature reviewed earlier describes as an autocratic or directive leadership style (Bass, 1997; Bogler, 2001; Eagly & Johannesen-Schmidt, 2001; Gastil, 1994; Yukl, 2002). The strength of this image was supported by data gathered from all stakeholder groups and emerged in interviews, surveys and observations conducted in all three schools. The image of directive leadership was inadvertently strengthened by the weak results of government policies aimed at decentralization of authority and teacher empowerment (Dalton & Ong, 2005; Hallinger et al., 2015; Martinez-Vazquez, 2005; Truong, 2013; Truong et al., *in press*).

With respect to school leadership practice in Vietnam, the study highlights the dangers that principals may face when relying on position power alone in the exercise of leadership. In Vietnam, the use of an autocratic/directive leadership style appears to be culturally, politically and institutionally legitimated. Nonetheless, our research *suggests* that leaders who complement this directive style with an emphasis on moral leadership may be able to achieve higher levels of staff commitment as well as goal achievement. Moreover, the study has identified some leadership practices that teachers (and principals) perceived as indicative of moral leadership in this cultural context. Notably, the values underlying moral leadership receive strong normative support within Vietnam's Confucian culture.

This study of principal leadership Vietnam also offers a useful perspective on international trends in school leadership research and practice by reinforcing the long-standing assertion that conceptualizations of 'leadership effectiveness' must be based upon a clear definition of desired organizational outcomes (Thomas, 1988). Over the past two decades, the global literature on school leadership has increasingly narrowed the 'defined outcomes' of 'successful school leadership' to the achievement of student performance on standardized tests. Yet, in Vietnam, cultural transmission and political reproduction *cum* social stability remain the highest priorities for the education system, and by implication for its school principals (Doan, 2005; Duc, 2008; Duggan, 2001; Hallinger & Truong, 2014; Hallinger et al., 2015). Thus, this study suggests that successful school leadership in Vietnam must be understood in terms of the goals of education as well as the sociocultural and political-institutional values and norms of the society.

In closing, we see rich potential in future studies that document how school leadership is enacted in different cultures (Den Hartog et al., 1999; Dimmock & Walker, 2005; Gerstner & Day, 1994; Hallinger & Leithwood, 1996; Lord et al., 2001; Resick et al., 2011). We find the current literature in our field rife with unquestioned assumptions concerning the aims of both education and leadership. Contrasting descriptions of leadership drawn from different cultures will enable us to assess more clearly the limits of the leadership knowledge base currently conveyed to educational leaders around the world.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

Notes

1. These included *Educational Administration Quarterly*, *Journal of Educational Administration*, *International Journal of Leadership in Education*, *School Leadership and Management*, *Educational Management Administration and Leadership*, *School Effectiveness and School Improvement*, *Leadership and Policy in Schools*.
2. Given the desire to maintain anonymity, we have not specified which of these participants *was* associated with which school.

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